CHAPTER 30

BRICKS, BREAKS AND BREAKTHROUGHS

November 2010

There is no information other than to be at the airport at 4am. It's not completely unheard of to go on team-building trips away before tours, especially ones as big as this one. Everything that has gone before in English cricket, ever since the disaster in Australia in 2006/07, has been focused back towards this moment. In the past though, an English team-building exercise has had the odd tendency to unfold into a sort of glorified stag do. Andy Flower is a different type of coach. This is a different type of team. Last year, on the first team trip Andy and Andrew Strauss had arranged, Freddie Flintoff had missed the team bus one morning and Ravi Bopara had forgotten his passport, which didn't go down particularly well. It wasn't funny and it wasn't acceptable. The response to that alone has led to a degree of trepidation in all that are meeting here at Gatwick, with the exception of Swanny who, when we are told that we are boarding a flight to Germany, sighs in relief and says to the group going through passport control, 'I knew we were going to the Munich Beer Festival,' punching the air.

On arrival, it becomes immediately obvious that we are not going to a beer festival. Blacked-out SUVs pick us up, no information given, and drive us deep into the forest. We are met by four men who look like SAS soldiers. There is no explanation still of who they are, of what we are doing, or where we are going. We are herded up. They strip us of everything but bare